

Chapter 1

The Stages of FI

“Every revolutionary idea seems to evoke three stages of reaction.

They may be summed up by the phrases:

- 1. It's completely impossible.*
- 2. It's possible, but it's not worth doing.*
- 3. I said it was a good idea all along.”*

—Arthur C. Clarke

We all know the reasons you cannot or do not *Choose FI*. You don't have to look far to find stories about young people crushed by student debt, soaring housing costs, and stagnant wages. On top of all that, investing is complicated. Against this backdrop, how can people possibly retire securely, let alone achieve FI before age sixty-five? It's easy to see why many people quickly become discouraged, and others never try.

Choosing FI becomes much easier if we reframe what FI means and how it empowers you. FI is often framed as a dichotomy: zero or one. You're either FI or you're not. You're working or you're retired.